

Expression: Around and Within

A collection of poems by Moses Yang

“Everybody is talented because everybody who is human has something to express.”
— Brenda Ueland

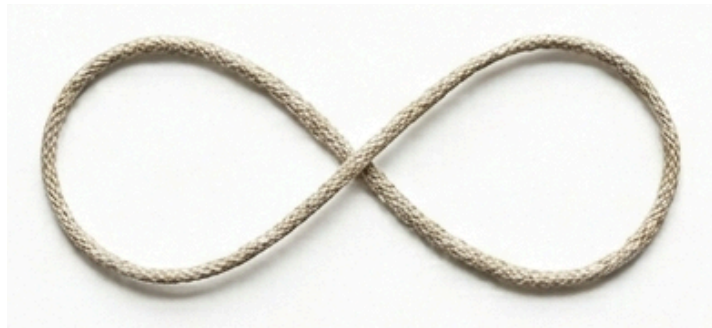
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Biography:

Moses Yang is a Junior studying Computer Science at Brown University. His interests span broadly, both inside and outside of poetry, and he enjoys trying new experiences, like poetry. Because of this, he has the most fun writing poems when experimenting with new topics, voices, and forms. He appreciates poetry most as an outlet of creativity and expression.

Tension



Expression

ex·pres·sion | /ik'spreSHən/

1. a double-edged sword nobody asked for. you can cut through anything but nothing at all.
2. nothing breaks into me except for the way you see into my soul. notice my fingers toying with my watch strap. my brown eyes averting yours. in through my tears and out through my shaky breath. a transparent window i never asked for.
3. load a bullet into the chamber and aim to fire. only for the sucker to jam at the heart of the body. begging for release just to be stifled by shame. puncture the cursed metal and burst out from within. spray away your fragments and gently touch the world with your jagged edges. deal with it later. you never asked for this.

Speak, To Me

just think a thought. just not too much. just watch out for overthinking. just like that. just a little too much. just spit it out before you chew it. just before you swallow it. just make sure you chew before you swallow. just maybe it'll work this time. just work for it next time. just try not to be scared. just be confident. just know it's okay to feel scared. just smell the flowers. just blow out the candles. just pretend like everyone's just wearing underwear on their heads. just take the first step. just know that it is what it is. just do it. just be here now. just do what i say. just don't try thinking your way out of thinking too much.

just like i imagined; just like i thought; just see that it'll never be just; justice for all; just not for me; justify why i keep caring; just know that mami'll never judge you; just like dad did; just in case you forgot; just so you know; just stop crying man; just man up; just be a man; just up ahead; just so you know man i; just can't keep doing this i; just hope you see; just how strong i am i'm; just not strong at all it's; just all a facade i'm; just holding on you see; just barely just; just know i'm scared; just what do i say;

just?

How To Teach Your Child Your Mother Tongue

1. Speak to your child in only your mother tongue.
2. Speak to your child in ways that they cannot understand.
3. Watch their face go blank in confusion.
4. Lament to yourself (and to your child) about how pitiful it is that they cannot speak your mother tongue. Make sure to perfect your facial expressions for this step, to look extra disappointed.
5. See them roll their eyes at you, then storm upstairs and slam their bedroom door.
6. Feel the frustration boiling in the pit of your stomach, rising up your throat.
7. Gag because the acidity reminds you of your childhood, when you could only afford to eat sweet potatoes.
8. Taste the metallic disgust in your mouth.
9. Think that your child would not have survived what you survived.
10. Let that thought pass.
11. Feel guilty that it came.
12. Look in the mirror and see your cheeks, flushed red from anger.
13. Glance at the mirror frame and observe its delicate flowery design.
14. Feel a pang in your heart as you remember that this was the one piece of home that you brought over with you to your new world.
15. Notice your mother's wrinkles and forehead creases imprinted on your own face.
16. Search for something of yourself that is only yours.
17. Find nothing. Find everything.
18. Remember that you barely spoke with your mother as a child, because she was outside all day, working the land and making trades just to put food on the table.
19. Remember that you cannot remember the sound of your mother's voice.
20. Miss your mother's touch. The bones close to the surface. The tough calluses from decades of toil.
21. Realize that you have been weeping.
22. Stand there for a moment longer than you mean to.
23. Decide, without deciding, to do something.
24. Head to the kitchen for a napkin.
25. Forget what you meant to do in the kitchen.
26. Grab an apple and the sweetest looking asian pear from the counter.
27. Grab a knife, still scented from dicing garlic.
28. Cut the fruit carefully, and chew the remaining flesh off the pits.
29. Plate the small pieces in a swirl, then lay a fork on top.
30. Walk upstairs, offering in hand.
31. Knock on their door.
32. Pray for a response.
33. Hear silence.
34. Notice your eyes welling up again.
35. Speak to your child in your mother tongue: "I cut some fruit for you. I'll leave it outside."

Dipty-pical Trauma

a bruise
the size of
a baseball
that we
never threw
together rotting
in my chest. a purple
stain so verbose it spoke
of your anger when you
slammed your hand on
the tabletop. felt bad
for the bugs they
must've thought
that the world
was ending.

i just
wanted the
best for you
for you i just
wanted the
best i'm
sorry if i failed you
to you i failed to say so-
rry it was my first time and
you were my first time cools
down when i see your tears and
it tears me up when i see your eyes
refusing to see mine when you come
home and i talk to you talk to me please i
just want to hear your voice like i used to
you used to call me daddy you used to
call me then you used to use excuses
to not call me then just called me
names if i could have restarted
my life i would i would pay
attention to my parents to
understand what not to
do i would pay atten-
tion to you to under-
stand what to do it
bugs me that you
fear me i think
the world

Trudging Downstream

ten feet underwater
my feet are dredges
shoveling through the
cemented sediment

edging onwards but
my shoes in the sand
feeling
the sand in my shoes
teaming up with gravity
hoping to
swallow me whole

just take me in
embrace me
and pucker up
to kiss me
at least then
I won't be

alone

at 4 in the afternoon
my stomach is angry
punching out my chest
begging to
grapple through my mouth
looking to
shred with my canines
because I've neglected him

since 9 in the morning
I've been quivering in my

off-white white sneakers
crusted with dust from
three rains ago

stifled by the choice
of four different hoodies
and two different chinos

as if
I would be any cooler
would be any hotter
from the mixing and matching
of six different colors

my ego is scattered and shattered
diffracting in fireworks
through the running water
I can't admit
I'm scared to swim with my school

afraid of the long lines
waiting for food
spotting someone I know
but don't really *know*
an awkward wave
a whispered hello

They must not know my name,
so I wait until 4 before I eat my first meal.

I trudge alone
a fish out of water
as a fish inside water
fighting downstream
when the rest float up.

Potential



The U.S. Bill of Rights

_____ respect _____ the _____

_____ speech _____ of the _____ people _____

_____ in time _____

_____ the people _____

_____ shall _____

_____ search _____

_____ for _____

_____ life, liberty _____

_____ shall _____

_____ enjoy the right _____

_____ to _____

_____ obtain _____ his

_____ power _____ to _____ Unite _____

_____ the people.

Formless

I have been turning over
the words in my mind
for a week now.

I thought they would flip cleaner
after some time.
Land right side up.
Settle and sizzle.
A perfect golden brown crust
with the right amount of crunch.

Instead I have churned
the words in my mouth
into butter.
So thick
I lost the original shape
and can barely make sense
of this gooey mess.

By the time I offer them
to you
I'm not sure
what state they're in.
Not liquid, not solid,
but not quite a gas either.

You take a bite anyway.
You say it's good.

I spend the next day
wondering if I said
the right thing
or just the thing I prepared.

There is a difference.
I'm not sure you can taste it.
I'm not sure I can either.

Under Control

I wish I could say I liked alcohol
but it burns, when I drink
I guess I know why it's called a shot
'cause vodka pricks as a needle stings
but what scares me more than the taste
I fear is slipping from the reins
for in normal times I overthink and overthink and overthink
...the words I say and the things I do...
gotta keep that perfect image
of a pretty mama's boy
who would never break
a soul a heart a promise
so don't you see —
how can I trust a version of me
that's not... *really* me?

drank and drunk and dizzy and woozy
tomato-red flushed face —
hot or shy or embarrassed or intoxicated
i can't really tell
it's all the same to me
my body is one and my feelings are two
but it's all the same one in one twisted pot
melting and melding my fears and inhibitions
evaporating into thick steam my mental strife
it's disgusting
how much the air reeks of anxiety
of a desire to be perfect
that's not... really me

Take A Breath

i
never know never learn
when to how to why to
cry let go break open go quiet
when i when we when you
fail to almost
find the words

Constraint or Restraint?

Java

```
while (True) {
    sleep();
    eat();
    code();
    repeat();

    if (time_for_a_leap_of_faith() == True) {
        // ignore your senses
        // your reason
        // chase your dreams
        // not just at night
        // but just after sunrise
        // when tomorrow
        // is the farthest away
        // and the warmth of the sun
        // seems ready to catch you
        // just a light ray away
        //
        // but it could be storming
        // is it hail or hell?
        // no matter
        // just turn up your wipers
        // and keep swimming on
        // because eventually
        // the dark clouds will boom on past
        // and the sun will be there
        // to catch you again
        write_poetry();
    }
}
```

Release



Hold My Hand

hold my hand
closer to your body after
you
 push
 me
out
 of
 you
into
 the
 world.

hold my hand
as I burst the bubbles
covering the lining of my lips
with my bibbling babbles
refusing to surrender control
to the mini fighter jet diving low
with target locked and ready to fire
but your comforting coos weaken my grip
as you grip my hand gently and
guide the plane to its landing strip

hold my hand
higher than I can reach
as I plant my feet firm
 shakely
stumbling forward about to land face first
arms swooping in like the seat of a swing
and root me in place
giving me the courage to run forward
and around
and towards you
to hug you

hold my hand
as you scold me
with tears streaming down both our faces
blotting the aged-gray carpet with blue stains of sorrow
I cried because
I cheated on my exams
and you were disappointed
in me and that hurt more than the ruler
on my hand and the bruises that followed
you cried because
your heart split in half and ha-
lf with every hit

hold my hand
as you teach me to cook with compassion
and sew with tenderness and love with intention
hoping one day your breathing touch
will live on through mine

hold my hand, mami
now covering yours
smaller than a starfish
but larger than love

hold my hand, mami
so we can walk together now
and

in another life.

My Mountain

Pedro

My rock.

A gray, moss-

covered boulder,

resting on the quilted

soft grass, unmoved for

millions and trillions of years.

Seen generations upon generations

of a family of squirrels in the tree next

door. Raised the tree from sapling to giant.

Snow

-capped

rugged

mountains

with stern bush

roots squeezing tight

the crevices and snaking

through the steep cliffside.

Born to be a watchguard and protector of the land / Standing through time, still.

You've been there for me / cast your shade on me / shielding me from the harsh rays

of the biting sun and the stalking vultures waiting ready to pounce / held me with your

arms raised high / helped me reach higher highs than I could alone / as I climbed atop your

shoulders / my boulder / and surveyed the lush valley floor spread vast across every dimension,

peering at the view between bouts of our laughter / the corners of your eyes crinkling as you smile \

I felt invincible standing on top of you, then within your arms, and eventually, finally, just next to you \

Remember when I used to wait for you when you came home from work, hide around the corner, and jump
out to scare you? I felt that way then, too / invincible / as if nothing could scratch my skin or bruise my heart \

I used to shadow you in the summertime / stuffy garage / performing surgery on your Toyota Camry older than me \

You grunted "pass me the screwdriver" / and as I did as you told / I still feel the calluses of your hands sanding my own \

Like a rock / Like a rock chewing at my hand with its divots and bumps, surface rough and imperfect / I winced in surprise, but

I was comforted / reminded of a rock that had been beaten and battered, eaten away by the eagerness of wind and water over ages,

yet softened and mellowed by the test of time / tenured with wisdom and understanding as it had seen life come and go, come and go \

You saw me trip on the branches and stumble on the pebbles as I tried to hike to the summit, but you caught me with your arms open wide \

See me now, on top of this world, if only for a moment / I'm away from you now, standing on you, yelling loud into the void my ecstasy and joy \

One day, Dad, I'll hike down the mountain, and you won't be under me / I worry / I might be lost without you there, always, as my sturdy foundation \

A Summer Long

I miss waking up next to you after a night in / Far after the birds have had their fill / Bodies sore still / I miss the shape of your hand as it presses firmly against mine / And fidgets her way to her assigned seat / I miss the pressure of my heart / Pounding / Against my chest as we scrambled along the railroad tracks / Like squirrels scurry between trees / It felt like our first kiss / Where we dangled our feet into Lake Unknown / Hoping we could see our future in the reflection / I miss the scent of your flowery perfume / As I nestle my nose into the nook of your neck / Like lock and key / Your hugs / I miss the weight of your body as you jump into mine and we spin in circles and laugh into the stars / I miss your joy / Warmth / As we roll around in the New England snow / Flicking at the flakes with our tongues / I miss running together / Away from responsibilities and closer to each other / I miss talking to you late at night / Far after the owls have found out who / Knowing our parents would scold us if they knew / Our secrets / I miss laughing with you / So much that our laughs become the joke / Your smile / I miss when you cried into my chest / Crying about how long it had been / And how much you had missed me / I miss your stifled nods and whimpered sounds / When I said we were together now / Knowing / I had cried a summer long / And longed for you for a summer

I know I'll see you soon / And I know someday / I'll miss that too.

小馬

It was love at first sight,
or so they say. But really,
it's impossible to know
whether you chose me
or I chose you
or we chose each other
or you were just
the cheapest Webkinz at Walmart.

They say they made you gallop in front of my carriage,
and peeped a small smile peeking out from under the tight covers.
I must've been too young to snap the shutters shut,
but maybe I wasn't
and maybe you were just
a passing gift
from one of my mother's students
or a hand-me-down
from one of my father's coworkers.
It was all the same to me.

You and me —
We would travel the world
riding into the sunset together
in the backseat of the family car.
We would play at the beach under the summer haze,
building a sandcastle just for us:
a knight in shining armor and his trusty stallion.
We would visit Taiwan's alleys during the night
— I clutched you so tight —
me feeding you baozi while you fed me company.

And when you made a mess of yourself
swimming at the ocean and eating too eagerly,
I would chide you for being so irresponsible.
Both of us knew that you would get thrown to the savages,
struggling to keep your neck upright in a whirlpool of muck,
then blasted to oblivion by the fiery roar of a sleepless dragon.

I would
wait
pudgy hands pressed
against the looming window
— of that darndest machine —
eyes turned down and forehead creased,
enough tears to play in the sea one more time.
I would wait for you to come back from your quest to snatch the golden fleece,
hoping you would be healed from your hurt.
Only to find
holes deepening along your seams
and yet another
crack
in your eyes
— catching the light almost
as if to promise that it would be okay.

There comes a time where a knight outgrows his horse.
I became too big for you to carry my burdens
and too ambitious for you to carry my dreams.
I ran to another land and
left you
to keep my stable stable.

But when I falter
on foreign words
and stumble into
uncomfortable comforts,
I remember how you taught me
to always charge galliantly into battle
fearful or not.
I remember how you would always
put one step before the other
and lift your chin high
no matter the cost
just to catch up to me
for one more warm embrace.

Ars Poetica

a poem to me is a little red wagon
 one that my sister
 had dad buy from Costco,
 and one that we built up together
 screwdrivers in hand.
 at a time when I knew
 righty tighty and lefty loosey
 but couldn't tell apart
 my lefts and rights
 'cuz to me it was all rights
 so long as my big sister was there,
 us not apart but a part of a team.

now don't ask me why
 but some how some way
 we decided ~~she decided and I followed~~
 it would be fun
 to embark our precious stuffies
 on a once in a lifetime journey
 to a roller coaster ride
 on our backyard hill

thinking back, in our naive naivety,
 we must've forgotten to tighten the seatbelts
 before inching the cart to the coaster's apex.
 then with a final push ~~probably from me~~
 the wagon was gone
 down the steep grassy hill.
 and together we watched it
 jumping on the fallen branches and
 slipping on the slick moss patches
 before slamming handle-side first
 into the prude oak tree
 which once hung
 dad's crude wooden swing.

of course, the animals all flew out—
 weren't you listening?

the seatbelts were loose
 and sure we were sad—
 cried for a moment or four
 for no moment more meant for
 crying and
 for no moment meant more for
 us, and my poetry.

we put the panda, the horse, and the cat
 altogether all together
 in the little red wagon
 and we guided it along
 gently down the slope
 until it rested at rest
 at the feet of the hill
 not defeated no, just
 resting.

you see, a poem to me is a little red wagon
 when I ship it off
 on its one-way journey out to the world
 it'll carry the weight of my
 most precious memories
 and deepest held emotions.

and when it
 falls flat and fails or
 stumbles in confusion,
 I can always come around and
 pack myself back in
 as cargo, in the little red wagon.
 just make sure to give it a hug and
 massage smooth its bruises and
 blow it a kiss before I let go again.

so there,
 trip my little red wagon, it's okay—
 weren't you listening?

Craft Statement

Writing a poem is just about the hardest thing I've done during my three years at Brown. And that's fighting toe to toe against battling through pneumonia, being the deciding bout for a team fencing competition, working through infinite coding assignments, and so much more. Why? As I attempt to portray in my *Ars Poetica* above, every time I write a poem, I want to pour my heart and soul into it. But the poems that we write are reviewed and criticized, and the hard truth is, no matter how beautiful and special a poem is to me, other people may (and probably won't) see it the same way. Having spoken about this with Professor Asakura during our 1:1, I feel reassured enough that poems don't need to be special to everyone — a poem special to yourself is all you need, and maybe you don't need that either. Still, as much as I hate to admit it, I find satisfaction in praise and affirmation, as I grew up being labeled the “smart and obedient” youngest son in the family, making it a label I've kept wanting to chase and maintain. My personality makes me want to put my best foot forward, seek perfection, but that's ultimately not always possible — there's been days where I became busy with other work that I couldn't drop for poetry, where I just procrastinated too long, or even times where I simply felt a lack of inspiration. How can you expect perfection when: 1) outside confounding factors exist and 2) it is so tough to capture feelings and emotions into sufficient enough words?

One of my main goals for this class was to better understand my thoughts and feelings, and be better able to share them outwardly. Here's a quote from my goals & intents letter:

By the end of the semester, I hope to have built skills to express my own feelings and experiences to others, and to better understand the emotions that I feel in

everyday life. I often feel that I am not opinionated enough, and I attribute this partially to my lack of introspection (or at least I think).

I cannot say for certain whether I understand my emotions better than at the beginning of the semester, as the emotions I attempt to express do not come from any specific thought process or straightforward manner. That is, I could not describe to you how my mind works to come up with writing content, but maybe it's possible that my brain has somehow been able to better understand my emotions subconsciously through the art of writing. However, I can say for sure that I have developed in expressing my own feelings and experiences to others. Early this semester, I had still felt the fear that I could not be as creative and open as others could, and that I could not open my mouth and press pen to paper in a way that tells a compelling story. While this fear still exists, I can confidently say that I feel somewhat more confident in this ability, improved upon by receiving feedback from my peers on my language and works, and reciting some of those works out loud. Still, I can see room for further growth in the way that I build and break my truth to express what I want to say, by improving the unexpectedness of my language.

To expand, I often felt hindered by my language — I often told instead of showed, and even when I did show, the language was usually simple. Maybe I need to read more works or make more of an effort to write down the interesting phrases that I hear used by others throughout everyday life. Maybe I just need to sit down with my work for longer periods of time and let the connections form themselves. Maybe I just need to write more poems. Maybe it's none of those — maybe my language usage is fine, and I'm just overseeing perfection. Still, I did notice that my language developed positively throughout the semester. I began to slowly stray away from clichés (seeing that word on every weekly poem will do that to you, I guess), started using more

wordplay, and broke up words and combined sentences in ways that added meaning and impact to the poem. What I find most interesting about this change in language is that while I've had many personal poems specifically stand out to me throughout the semester, the language in those poems has not particularly stuck to one type of style. Early this semester, I tended to lean towards more lyrical phrases and nice sounding sounds, often counting out the syllables, reading out loud to myself, and using alliteration. I would play with the rhythm of lines using anaphoras and line/stanza breaks and enjambment, to add breath into the reading to create pauses aimed at getting the reader to contemplate, feel, and relate. Some examples of my favorite works with these traits include *A Summer Long*, *Hold My Hand*, and *Sweeping*. Later into the semester, I found myself engaging in wordplay frequently, often reusing sounds or words in different ways to get the reader to slow down to think about my poem instead of rushing through it, even though these similar sounds often lead to a quicker pace of reading. Some of my favorite works with these traits include *Dipty-pical Trauma*, "Speak, To Me", and *Ars Poetica*.

An observation I've made is that the form, voice, and style of my poems shift frequently as we interacted with various works throughout the semester. I imagine this was the point: when you start learning photography, you don't pigeonhole yourself into only shooting portraits — you experiment with landscapes, street photography, sports photography, etc. before you hone in on your niche. And even after you find your niche, you often take a step back and engage in the other types of photography to improve those skills, but to also simultaneously benefit the nature and quality of the photos in your own niche. But this is just an educated guess from me. After all, I only started playing around with photography this semester, and I have a lot to learn beyond my clocked hours on YouTube! And yet, out of a pile of poems, you can probably still pick out

which ones are mine — they all contain some characteristic tint that I do not currently have the knowledge to name. Maybe it's the clash of hurt and love. How I hurt and was hurt and how I love and will love. How I want you to feel what I feel so my hurt is less and my love is more.

I'm still quiet. I'm still uncertain. I'm still scared. Rome wasn't built in a day [cliche]. But it sure is nice to confirm for myself that I'm not a robot — that I feel emotions that I may not always know how to express best but have now shown that I, at the very least, can express. I'm not sure how I'll bring this into my life moving forward. I'll have to think about it. I still don't think I can tell a story like my dad can. I still don't think I can take over the conversation at the dining room table. But I do think this is a step in the right direction.